

putsch

A violent attempt to overthrow a government.

recession

A reduction in the economic activity of a country, though less serious than a depression. A recession is often defined as having occurred when economic output has declined for two successive three-month periods.

Reformation

The Christian reform movement of the 16th century, in which many churches and individuals broke from the Western [*Catholic*] Church headed by the pope in Rome.

Renaissance

A cultural phase of European history, centered on Italy in the 15th and early 16th centuries, that involved the rediscovery of the cultural achievements of ancient Greece and Rome. This in turn became the inspiration for new ideas in literature and the creation of new artworks.

reparations

A term that came into use after World War I for payments made by the defeated countries to the victors, regarded as being in recompense for their aggression. An older term for the same thing is **indemnity**.

republic

Any country not headed by a hereditary king, prince, or emperor. Modern republics are usually headed by presidents and range from democratic regimes to dictatorships.

republicanism

(1) Support for a *republic* as the preferred form of government. (2) Beliefs and values associated with the Republican Party in the US. (3) In Irish contexts, support for the complete independence of Ireland from the UK.

restoration/Restoration

The restoring of a previous state of affairs. In British history, the Restoration refers to the return of the British monarchy in 1660, after the English Civil War and *Commonwealth*, and the years following this.

Roman Church

The Western branch of the Christian Church, which developed under the leadership of the pope in Rome, and in which church services are, or were, conducted in Latin. See also *Catholic*, *Greek Church*.

Romantic Movement

A many-sided cultural and artistic movement in Europe that reached its peak in the early 19th century. It included an increased appreciation of nature and an emphasis on feelings and emotions in contrast to reason.

royal minority

The period when the monarch of a country is still a child (a minor).

satrap

A provincial governor in the ancient Persian Empire; also, a subordinate ruler generally.

scholasticism

The approach to reasoning and knowledge that is characteristic of centres of higher education during the Christian *Medieval period*.

sect

A religious group or organization that holds distinctive or nonstandard beliefs. The term is often used to imply that the views held are doubtful, or even heretical.

sectarian

Displaying hostile attitudes to people from a different social grouping, especially those adhering to a different denomination of the same religion.

secular

Nonreligious.

segregation

Separation, in particular separation of one race from another within a racist or *apartheid* social system.

self-determination

Situation in which a people or nation are able to choose their own government, or to govern themselves.

Senate

(1) The assembly that acted as the main ruling body in ancient Rome (eventually losing most of its powers to the emperors). (2) The upper legislative house of the US *Congress*, or of other legislatures that are similarly organized.

serf

A *peasant* living in a condition of semi-slavery, with no right to leave the land of the landowner for whom he or she works.

shogun

A hereditary commander-in-chief in Japan. For various periods in Japanese history, shoguns, rather than the emperor, held the real power.

social democracy

Formerly another term for *socialism* or *communism*. In modern usage it refers to a moderate form of socialism that is compatible with democracy and *liberalism*.

socialism

Term used for a variety of left-wing ideologies and movements that all involve some government intervention in society and the economy, with the goal of redistributing wealth for the common good. Socialist movements have ranged from the moderate and democratic to revolutionary communist movements (see *democracy* and *communism*).

sovereignty

Complete legitimate authority over a given territory.

soviet

One of the many elected councils that operated at all levels of society in the former USSR. **Soviet Union** is another name for the USSR.

Soviet Bloc

Another name for the *Eastern Bloc*.

speculation

An economic term for the buying and selling of shares, or other tradeable assets, for the purpose of making a profit if the price rises or falls in the way that the speculator predicts.

state

(1) An independent country. (2) A self-governing region within a country. (3) The governmental apparatus of a country.

stock exchange

An organization that allows trading in shares of companies, government bonds, and other financial assets.

suffrage

The right to vote, especially in a public election. A **suffragist** is an advocate of the right to vote; especially, in many cases, the rights of women.

sultan

A title, equivalent to king or emperor in some *Islamic* contexts and cultures (see *Islam*).

suzerainty

Feudal overlordship (see *overlord*). Also, the supremacy of one state over a less powerful one.

synod

A church council or assembly.

technocrat

(1) A member of a technical elite. (2) Someone who regards political problems as being best approached by seeking technical solutions, rather than via ideologies or value judgments.

tetrarchy

A governing arrangement in parts of the Roman Empire whereby a region was divided into four subdivisions, each with its own ruler (**tetrarch**). Also the name for the district ruled by a particular tetrarch.

theocracy

Rule by a priest or a priesthood.

tithe

A tax imposed for the upkeep of the Church, especially in the *medieval period*, usually consisting of one-tenth of the agricultural produce of a given piece of land.

totalitarianism

A form of *authoritarian* rule in which the government aims to control the details of individual people's lives and thoughts, treating individual freedom as unimportant compared with the state.

trade union

An association of workers, formed to advance their economic interests and to provide mutual support.

tribune

A title for various officials in ancient Rome. A tribune of the people was one of two (later more) officials appointed to protect the rights of the common people against the nobility. A military tribune was an officer attached to a *legion*.

triumph

An official victory procession in ancient Rome.

trusteeship

Situation in which a territory is administered by a particular country on behalf of the United Nations, for the benefit of the territory's inhabitants. See also *mandate*.

usurp

To seize power from another in a manner regarded as wrongful.

Utopia

An imaginary, ideal world. The name, meaning "nowhere," comes from the title of a book by Sir Thomas More, published in 1516. The word **Utopian** has come to be applied to any impracticably idealistic plan.

vassal

In the feudal system (see *feudalism*), a person holding land from a superior, in return for offering them allegiance; also used more generally for a servant or subordinate.

viceroy

A person who governs as the deputy of a monarch in a colony, region, or province.

Viet Cong

The political and military organization that carried out guerrilla warfare and other activities during the Vietnam War. Although it claimed to be an independent rebel movement within the then non-communist South Vietnam, in fact, it was largely controlled by communist North Vietnam (see *communist*).

Zionist

A supporter of the creation of an independent state for the Jewish people. Also, following the creation of Israel in 1948, a strong supporter of Israel's continued existence as a Jewish state.